

Structuralism



The structuralist idea that elements of culture must be understood in terms of their relationship to a larger, overarching system or structure influenced many art forms, including architecture.

Existentialism became the predominant philosophy in France and much of Europe after the Second World War. By the 1960s, however, a rival movement began among French intellectuals. Sartre's Marxism had caused him to modify his ideas of human freedom and choice, and the next generation rejected phenomenology and existentialism completely. Instead, Marxist philosophers such as Louis Althusser saw human behaviour as

determined by structures, and philosophy as a discourse governed by linguistic structure. Structuralism, as this approach was called, was influenced by the semiotic theories of Barthes, and closely connected to the French tradition of literary criticism. It also informed the psychoanalytic theories of Jacques Lacan and the anthropology of Claude Lévi-Strauss. As it developed in the work of Althusser and Barthes, it was adopted by younger left-wing philosophers such as Michel Foucault and Jacques Derrida. They argued that, since discourse and human behaviour are determined by linguistic structures, they, too, can be explained by linguistic analysis.